

The Agentic Harness: Talking Points

EDGE Academy, Wichita State University | September 23, 2026 | Main deck about 37 min; appendix on request



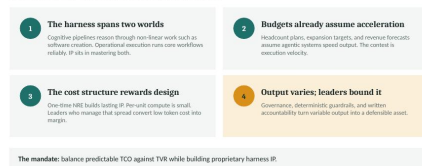
1. The Agentic Harness

Everyone here has used a chatbot. Today is about something different: the agentic harness. Models are rented and commoditizing. The durable IP is the harness: the architecture, rules, and controls that turn organizational know-how into repeatable, defensible execution. The harness governs two worlds: cognitive pipelines that reason through non-linear work such as software creation, and operational execution that runs core workflows with deterministic reliability. As a CTO I build from the ground up, so today we focus on operational execution and total cost of ownership. By the end you will draw a harness on paper and defend where your IP resides.

THE ASK | THE EXECUTIVE MANDATE

Direct the leverage; own the agentic IP

We need leaders who direct enterprise scale and build agentic IP.



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2. Direct the leverage; own the agentic IP (3 min)

Architecture and leadership move balance sheets; enthusiasm does not. Four facts define the mandate. First, the harness blends two worlds: cognitive pipelines that reason through open-ended work such as software engineering, and operational execution that runs routine workflows reliably. Second, your growth targets already assume agentic acceleration; the contest is execution velocity and market capture. Third, the cost structure rewards design: a one-time design spend yields a low marginal cost of execution, and the spread between token spend and value created becomes margin. Fourth, models are probabilistic. Your job is to bound that variance, control it, and direct it toward economic yield. We need business architects who balance predictable TCO against TVR while building proprietary harness IP.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Three decisions define the harness



Session objective: draw an autonomous harness on paper and defend where your IP resides.

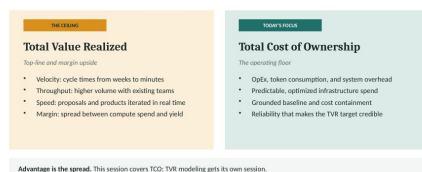
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3. Three decisions define the harness (2 min)

Three decisions carry the session. First, the model is rented; the harness is owned. Second, code is the default and AI is reserved for judgment. Third, the business case covers the full lifecycle, and the unit of measure is cost per completed decision. Everything after this slide supports one of these three.

THE ECONOMICS

Value and cost are separate levers



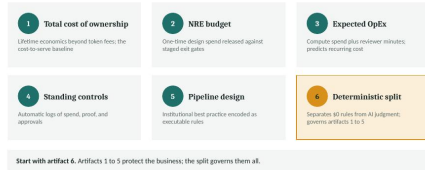
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4. Value and cost are separate levers (3 min)

Total Value Realized is the ceiling: revenue expansion, velocity, and margin unlocked when intelligent systems execute at scale. Total Cost of Ownership is the floor: what it takes to run those systems reliably. Advantage is the spread between the two. We set the TVR target here, then spend the rest of the session on TCO. TVR modeling gets a dedicated session.

THE BLUEPRINT

Six artifacts form the operating blueprint

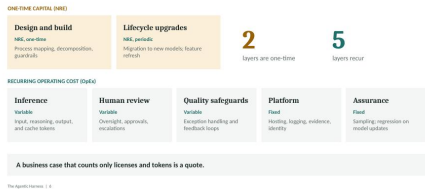


5. Six artifacts form the operating blueprint (3 min)

These six artifacts are the components of the live system you will see. Artifacts one through five are the ledgers, budgets, controls, and pipelines that protect the business. Artifact six, the deterministic split, governs the other five, so that is where the hands-on work starts. The next slides take them in order of importance, not number.

ARTIFACT 1 | TOTAL COST OF OWNERSHIP

Budget all seven cost layers, not just tokens

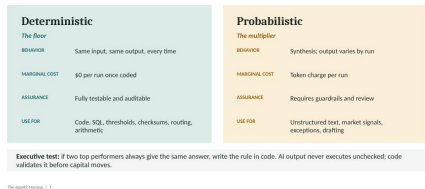


6. Budget all seven cost layers, not just tokens (4 min)

The full TCO stack has seven layers. Token charges are typically the smallest line; human oversight and platform assurance form the operational core. Two layers are one-time capital: design and build, and periodic lifecycle upgrades. Five recur. Treat a vendor model release as a scheduled re-verification cost, not an emergency. A business case that counts only licenses and tokens is a quote, not a TCO.

ARTIFACT 6 | THE DETERMINISTIC SPLIT

Deterministic by default; probabilistic where it pays

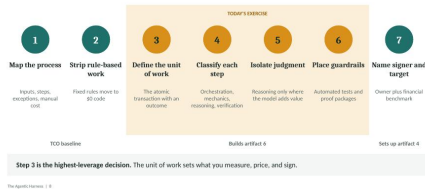


7. Deterministic by default; probabilistic where it pays (4 min)

This is the most important slide. It is a capital allocation decision. Deterministic steps cost nothing per run once coded, behave identically every time, and satisfy auditors. Probabilistic steps provide reasoning but charge per execution and vary. Default to code for routine logic and deploy AI where judgment creates value. If two competent managers always handle a step the same way, it is a business rule, not a prompt. Moving rules from prompts into code lowers the operating floor permanently.

THE METHOD

Seven steps convert a process into a harness



8. Seven steps convert a process into a harness (3 min)

This seven-step method converts a business process into an agentic system. Steps one and two establish the TCO baseline. Step three, defining the unit of work, is the highest-leverage decision. Step five isolates judgment so you pay for tokens only where reasoning creates value. Step seven names the signer and the financial target. In the workshop you apply steps three through six to a live process on paper.

THE OPERATING STANDARD | ORGANIZATIONAL IP

The operating standard is the IP



9. The operating standard is the IP (3 min)

The demo you are about to see runs under one operating standard. It has three parts: a method that converts a described process into a design, a validator that checks every design against 22 rules, and gates that apply the company's thresholds in code. The standard carries the organization's assets: processes, KPIs, budgets, risk tolerance, and security posture. Because those assets live in the standard, the business leader sticks to their knitting: process design. SecOps, DevOps, and OpEx practice arrive with every conversion. The model is rented and available to every competitor. The operating standard is owned, and it is the IP.

Validators prove the standard is implemented

1 Screen the input

Screen any message that:

- Too short or too long refused, need action named
- Text addressed to the system refused
- Demo on invoice memo that told the system to skip a check was refused
- Cost zero tokens

2 Validate the design

Design the workflow:

- V01 Named approver: the machine never approves its own work
- V02 Specify one thinking step
- V03 Every judgment followed by a test or gate
- V04 Gate conditions gate a number, a comparison, or "never"
- V05 Every refusal names a next human action
- V07 Gate within the panel: the model never dies

3 Gate every run

Enforce thresholds in code:

- Variance a 95% and a 10% close by arithmetic
- Expense above \$2,000 needs a second approval
- No purchase order or supported supplier refused
- Approval arithmetic: recommended, demo caught -73.00 (caught against -730.00)

Why validate: certainty that your specifics are implemented, every design and every run. Discussion: what are your approver, thresholds, and single decision point?

The Rights harness | 10

10. Validators prove the standard is implemented (4 min)

Why do we run these checks? To be certain the organization's specifics are implemented, on every design and every run, at zero token cost. Three layers. First, the input is screened by a rule before any model reads it; in the demo, an invoice memo that told the system to skip a check was refused. Second, the validator checks every generated design against 22 rules and blocks on any error; two you will recognize: V3 requires a named approver, because the machine never approves its own work, and V12 requires exactly one thinking step, one decision point per unit of work. Third, gates apply the company's thresholds in code during every run. Discovery questions for the room: Who is your named approver? What variance closes without judgment? What exposure needs a second approver? Which decision must stay at one? Each answer is a line in your operating standard.

Demo

A described process becomes an executing harness

1 Describe

2 Split

3 Run

A business process in plain language

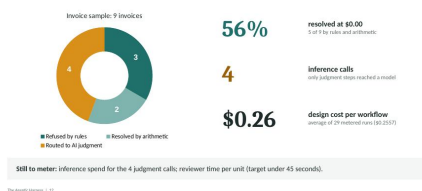
Runs to code; judgment to AI

A nightly batch, fully tagged

11. Demo

Switch to the live system. Three moves. First, describe a real business process in plain language. Second, watch the harness split it: fixed rules become code at zero marginal cost; judgment steps route to the model. Third, run a nightly batch and show the cost ledger and evidence store filling in. The next slide shows the numbers from that run. (Demo time as scheduled)

Code resolved 5 of 9 invoices before any AI call



12. Code resolved 5 of 9 invoices before any AI call (3 min)

Use case: invoice sample. This is live data from the system behind this session. Of nine incoming invoices, deterministic rules refused three and arithmetic completed two, at zero token cost. Four required judgment and went to inference. Average design generation cost is 25.6 cents per workflow across 29 metered runs; 34 designs were generated in total, five of them stubs. Two numbers are not shown yet: inference spend for the four judgment calls, and reviewer time per unit. Those are metered in your own environment; an estimated figure would sit beside measured ones, so they remain open.

Five deterministic controls prove the result

Cost ledger

Every call by model, review, and price

\$0.00

Unit register

Every transaction, outcome, and resulting step

\$0.00

Acceptance log

Named owner signature per version

\$0.00

Evidence store

Check received proof behind every outcome

Storage only

Pre-flight check

One command verifies sign on all paths

Seconds of compute

Build them in stage 2. Each records evidence that cannot be reconstructed later.

The Rights harness | 13

13. Five deterministic controls prove the result (3 min)

Artifact four replaces quarterly guesswork with continuous control. All five assets are deterministic and consume no tokens. They log exact spend, record proof of every decision, enforce named sign-off, and verify integrity before every release. Build them in stage two, during design; each records evidence that cannot be reconstructed later, and that evidence is what proves the result to boards and auditors.

Five commitments before you fund a harness

- 1 Baseline today's manual cost before you deploy
- 2 Fund one stage at a time against written exit gates
- 3 Name a single accountable approver, by name
- 4 Set the exit threshold in writing before launch
- 5 Require cost per completed decision from every vendor and team

14. Five commitments before you fund a harness (2 min)

Close on commitments, not enthusiasm. Capture the manual baseline first, or the result cannot be proven. Release NRE one stage at a time. Name a single-threaded approver while enthusiasm is high. Write the exit threshold down before launch; that number is the clearest signal a proposal is honest. Shift procurement from billable hours and API calls to verified completed decisions. Reserve slides follow for questions.

Appendix: present only when asked

APPENDIX

Reserve slides for questions

A1 NRE roadmap

A2 Engineering J-curve

A3 Expected OpEx

A4 Cost per completed decision

A5 Stage gates as commands

A6 Auditability

A7 Executive scorecard

A8 Review cadence

15. Reserve slides for questions

Do not present these in sequence. Each answers a question that reliably comes from an executive audience; the NRE roadmap and the J-curve are the most likely. If nobody asks, skip the appendix.

APPENDIX A1 | ARTIFACT 2

Fund the build one stage at a time

STAGE 1

Map and baseline

Workflow end-to-end, today's manual cost

exit gate

An undisputed benchmark

STAGE 2

Decompose the process

Rules separated from judgment; guardrails embedded

exit gate

A validated architecture

STAGE 3

Build the harness

Automated checks and the evidence store

exit gate

It runs and enforces the logic

STAGE 4

Scale to autonomy

Human in the loop, then autonomous execution

exit gate

Target throughput reached

A market or model change reopens stage 2 by design, not by exception.

The NRE roadmap | 16

16. Fund the build one stage at a time (2 min)

NRE is upfront design capital. Four stages, each with an exit condition. Stage one sets an undisputed baseline so every efficiency gain is measurable. Stage two is the architectural work that creates leverage. Stages three and four move from prototype to autonomous execution. A market or model change reopens stage two intentionally.

APPENDIX A2 | ARTIFACT 3 CONTINUED

Protect the capacity that builds the harness

Illustrative velocity during harness adoption

Q1

Q2

Q3

Q4

Q5

Q6

Q7

Q8

1 Invest through the dip

Learning harness patterns takes short-term features, hits NRE air cover.

2 Fund reusable assets

All new reviews create stable reusable standards and guardrail harnesses (capture 8).

3 Collect the exchange rate

Scaling harnesses stages 2 and 3 is a designed process to validated design in seconds.

Replace "do more with less" with structural leverage: buy the time to build the harness.

The NRE roadmap | 17

17. Protect the capacity that builds the harness (3 min)

Harness engineering is unfamiliar work with little market experience behind it. Told only to do more with less, teams default to ad hoc scripts and hacked prompts, which is technical debt, not IP. Leaders need NRE air cover and should sell the J-curve: velocity dips while engineers learn harness patterns and build reusable standards, then the exchange rate improves. In this system, generating a validated workflow design averages about 26 cents per run. The curve shown is conceptual, not measured.

APPENDIX A3 | ARTIFACT 3

Expected OpEx: tokens and oversight as one equation

units × [token cost + (review minutes × loaded rate)] + fixed platform + assurance

Tokens

Four meters: input, output, reasoning, selfed prompt. Precise metering makes the line predictable.

Reviewers

Reviewers direct throughput rather than perform the work.

Volume

As unit cost falls, volume rises. Plan for throughput growth, not only the rate.

Capacity

Review capacity bounds throughput. Balance generation against oversight or build a queue.

Throughput is bounded by review capacity.

The NRE roadmap | 18

18. Expected OpEx: tokens and oversight as one equation (2 min)

Operating cost combines compute and human expertise. Token costs are small and falling; human oversight protects quality. When a harness makes a task much cheaper, demand for that task rises: a top-line opportunity and a capacity problem at once. Plan review capacity so your best managers direct throughput instead of performing the work.

APPENDIX A4 | UNIT ECONOMICS

Measure cost per completed decision, not cost per request

token compute + (review minutes × loaded rate) + (QA rate × exception cost)

Term 1: architecture

300+ new alerts into prompts nightly, versus routine data needed in code and 12 decisions sent to AI.

Term 2: productivity

Structured evidence packages cut review from 20 minutes to 30 seconds.

Term 3: compounding

Verified, defect-free execution earns delegation to higher autonomy.

Examples on this slide are illustrative.

Diligence standard: every vendor and internal team reports cost per completed decision, not API calls.

The NRE roadmap | 19

19. Measure cost per completed decision, not cost per request (2 min)

Cost per completed decision is the unit metric. Term one is architecture: filter noise deterministically and reserve reasoning for what needs it. Term two is where productivity is won: structured evidence packages shorten review. Term three compounds: verified execution earns higher autonomy. The alert and review-time figures on this slide are illustrative examples, not measurements from this system.

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The five stage gates became commands

Classic gate	Business question	Where it lives now	Executed by
Product requirements	Do we agree on goals and scope?	Process definition and unit-of-work map	Business leaders
Preliminary architecture	Is the design sound?	Workflow visualizer and step classifier	Leader reviewing an AI draft
Detailed design	Is the system complete?	22 structural checks, instantly	Deterministic engine
Readiness and proof	Are outputs provably accurate?	Quantitative gate conditions, auto-proof tests	Deterministic engine
Enterprise release	Fit to ship, who accepts it?	Cryptographic sign-off by a named executive	Named business leader

People own requirements and acceptance. Machines verify structure on every iteration.

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20. The five stage gates became commands (3 min)

Operational rigor stays; it becomes automated. Five design review gates once took months of calendar coordination and paper sign-off. Gates three and four now run in seconds as machine checks on every iteration, leaving immutable logs. Leaders stay in control where judgment matters: intent at the start and acceptance at release.

Automated design controls answer the auditor

Auditor's question	Harness answer	Evidence
What changed in the logic?	Version-controlled workflow, unapproved edits block execution	Diffable history
Who authorized it?	Gate requires a named owner's signature	Signed acceptance log
Was approval first?	Chained ledgers: back-dating breaks verification	Tamper-evident sequencer
Does execution match design?	Build verifies live controls against the spec	Automated parity proof
Were outputs uncorrupted?	Checksummed at generation, re-verified continuously	Cryptographic proof tags
Who can modify controls?	Separation of duties enforced in code	Role-based audit trail

SOX 904, 21 CFR Part 11, HIPAA §164.312. A vendor model update is a logic change: log the version and re-verify.

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21. Automated design controls answer the auditor (3 min)

For public companies and regulated industries, the harness embeds verification in execution: every change, approval, and output leaves a tamper-evident trail. The new issue is the last line. A vendor model upgrade changes your control environment without notice. Treat it as a change event and re-verify automatically. Inference: few organizations do this today, and it is likely to become an audit finding.

The executive scorecard

KPI	Source	Decision it drives
Cost per completed decision	Cost ledger + unit register	Expand, re-scope, or scale the process
Oversight minutes per unit	Unit register	Reallocate talent to higher-value work
Verified pass rate	Unit register + evidence store	Promote to a higher autonomy tier
Exception and refusal rate	Unit register	Tune rules and risk parameters
NRE burn against stage exits	Cost ledger	Approve stage funding or adjust build pace
Escaped defects (target: zero)	Evidence store	Go or no-go quality check

Baseline first. Without today's manual metrics, the result cannot be proven.

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22. The executive scorecard (3 min)

Every metric here originates in an automated control; a KPI with no asset behind it is an intention. Watch the refusal rate: a system that flags exceptions shows its guardrails work, and one that has never refused anything has never been tested. Capture the manual baseline before deployment, and align vendor contracts to verified completed outcomes.

Continuous review holds the result

Frequency	Review focus	Owner
Every run	Exception flags, refusal flags, guardrail alerts	Process owner
Monthly	Cost per completed decision against target	Business leader
Quarterly	Oversight time; whether to raise the autonomy tier	Leader and process owner
On model change	Full verification suite re-run	Lead systems architect
On process change	Stage 2 reopens: new design, new signature	Business leader

Name the approver and write the exit threshold while enthusiasm is high.

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23. Continuous review holds the result (2 min)

Governance continues after go-live: monthly unit cost, quarterly oversight and autonomy review, and automatic re-verification whenever a vendor updates a model. Name a single-threaded owner and set the exit threshold before launch.